

This 22-year-old guy looked at me, terrified. “Tell me, Kevin,” he said. “What should I do?”

I asked if he wanted my honest answer, and he said yes.

“Which one’s easier to replace?” I asked. “The business you are growing into an empire, or this girlfriend?”

He didn’t answer. I proceeded to make my case.

“If you’re financially successful, you’re going to have a lot of women interested in you. And it certainly sounds like you’re going to be successful. I know you’ve been with this girl for the last four years, but it doesn’t sound like she’s ready to take the journey that you have to take when you’re an entrepreneur who is building his business. She doesn’t want to be part of that—she wants you to give it up for her. But what you are building with your company is unique. It’s a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity that very few people get. I’m recommending that you don’t blow it. Right now, that means your business needs you 24/7. Your girlfriend will either get on board or somebody else will.”

A wave of chatter broke out in the audience, and I could tell not everyone agreed with me. I decided this was a great way to stimulate a group discussion. So I put the question to them: What do you think he should do?

The students went nuts. One young woman said, “Mr. O’Leary, you’re an animal! Why does it have to be a choice between love and money?” I reminded her that I wasn’t the one who said it had to be a choice; the guy’s girlfriend had set the terms.

We didn’t break that class for 45 minutes. In the end, I put it to a vote. Should the student stay with his business or stay with his girlfriend? The class voted with me. Pragmatism won.

I’ve got nothing against this girlfriend; I actually respect her. But she simply wasn’t the right partner for him at that point in time. If they *had* married and the business had continued to be successful, if she had been willing to give him maybe five more years, they might have enjoyed a very comfortable, happy future together. But she wasn’t willing to wait, and he wasn’t willing to lose momentum on a really good thing. They obviously weren’t right for each other, because they weren’t speaking the same money language.